terrorism, especially for the smaller Western states. China decided to play on their concerns. It helped that China was by now within the NSG (this was not the case in 1998). Chinese diplomats began to work on the NSG members, especially the 'purists', highlighting that, on the one hand, the Americans had called for the strengthening of the international non-proliferation regime to deprive the 'rogue' states of their right to have nuclear energy while, on the other hand, it was violating the existing international rules and regulations to help India when it suited the global interests of America. Well-respected Chinese commentators such as the former Chinese Ambassador to India Cheng Ruisheng wrote about the 'big turn-about' that America had made.

'The fact that the United States could give up part of its interests on non-proliferation in order to realize its strategic objective of forming an alliance with India has fully reflected the flexibility of US policy,' he wrote. [16] The *World Affairs* magazine, which was published under the aegis of the Chinese Foreign Ministry, posited that India was dangling civil nuclear cooperation as a bait to break down the restrictions imposed by the NSG and to get parity with the nuclear weapons states. [17] Such arguments were intended to scare the small Western countries and to strengthen the resolve of the opposition, especially the so-called Group of Six—Ireland, New Zealand, Austria, Switzerland, Norway and the Netherlands. This was classic Chinese diplomacy, what former NSA S. Menon called a form of diplomatic guerrilla warfare. [18] China hid behind the curtain and manipulated the 'purists' in the NSG, much like Ci Xi, Dowager Empress of China had done with Emperor Guang Xu at the end of the nineteenth century.

India had learned from the experience of dealing with China in 1998–1999. This time, unlike at the time of the nuclear tests, the Chinese were briefed early in New Delhi along with the